IOWN

The Morning Brief

APRIL 14, 2026

Resistance Test

Monday's rally cleared the first resistance band, setting up the major $691.90-$693.20 zone ahead of March PPI, the bank earnings kickoff, and Fed speakers.

SPY	BRENT CRUDE	GOLD	BITCOIN	FEAR & GREED
$686.10 ↑0.98%	~$98 ↓1%	~$4,770 ↓0.4%	~$72,500 · Flat	21 · Extreme Fear

SECTION 01

Markets

THE BLOCKADE RALLY — EQUITIES ABSORB THE ESCALATION AND PUSH HIGHER

Monday's session produced a counterintuitive rally in the face of material escalation. The S&P 500 rose 0.98%, the Dow gained 0.60%, the Nasdaq added 1.03%, and the Russell 2000 led at +1.44%. UVXY collapsed 5.61% as volatility compressed despite the active US Navy blockade of Iranian ports that began at 10 AM ET Monday. Tech (+2.10%) and financials (+1.75%) led sectors; staples (–1.00%) and utilities (–1.21%) were the only meaningful laggards. Reports that the US and Iran are considering further negotiations ahead of the two-week ceasefire window expiration appear to have steadied risk sentiment even as the physical blockade remained in effect. Oil is retreating in early Tuesday trading, with Brent near $98 and WTI near $96.57—a reversal from Monday's 7% blockade-driven surge. S&P futures are little changed in the premarket as the market awaits March PPI at 8:30 AM ET and the start of Q1 bank earnings season.

CARSON'S TECHNICAL FRAMEWORK — FIRST RESISTANCE BAND CLEARED, MAJOR ZONE AHEAD

Monday's advance carried SPY through the lower resistance band on Carson's published map. The session's intraday high of $686.30 cleared both $683.70 and $685.85, and the close at $686.10 settled inside the band. Both levels are now marked as hit in the technical register. The next reference point is Carson's major resistance zone at $691.90-$693.20, approximately 0.8–1.0% above Monday's close. Carson expects a meaningful concentration of sell-side order flow in this zone, though his working view allows for a sustained breakout; all-time highs are the stated upside objective. On the downside, the published support at $645.80 remains untouched—Monday's intraday low of $676.58 held well above—leaving the full retracement target intact as a downside anchor should the order-flow resistance at $691.90-$693.20 prove durable.

RESISTANCE (MAJOR)	**SPY $691.90–$693.20 · Order-flow concentration · ACTIVE**
RESISTANCE (INTERMEDIATE)	**SPY $683.70 / $685.85 · HIT on April 13 at $686.30**
SUPPORT	**SPY $645.80 · Retracement target · ACTIVE (untouched)**

DIGITAL SLEEVE LEADS — MARA +8.60%, HUT +5.56%, COIN +3.98%

The digital asset sleeve was the clear leadership cohort on Monday. MARA surged 8.60%, HUT gained 5.56%, COIN rose 3.98%, and HOOD added 3.58%. Bitcoin consolidated near $72,500 after last week's rally. IBIT and ETHA were roughly flat on the day but the mining and brokerage names captured the operating leverage. The setup has structural backing: Morgan Stanley's MSBT Bitcoin ETF launch remains pending, Iran's implementation of a cryptocurrency-based Hormuz toll system creates ongoing real-world demand, and the Clarity Act regulatory overhang has stabilized. ADP rallied 3.49% despite a BMO price target cut, a reversal that reflects short-covering rather than a fundamental shift. The semiconductor sleeve was mixed: LRCX +1.39%, KEYS +2.14%, QCOM +2.48%, NXPI +1.78% led, while NVDA (+0.36%), AMD (+0.73%), and TSM (–0.28%) consolidated.

FAST MISSED — THE FIRST Q1 EARNINGS MISS IN THE PORTFOLIO

Fastenal (FAST) reported Q1 EPS of $0.30 against the $0.3047 consensus estimate, a narrow miss that sent the stock down 6.85% on Monday. The company flagged a flat growth outlook even as results remained largely in line with prior guidance. FAST is an industrial distribution name that historically tracks the manufacturing cycle; the cautious outlook suggests that customer capital spending decisions are being deferred amid the ongoing energy shock and elevated input costs. The ISM Manufacturing Prices subindex at 78.3 in March confirmed the cost pressure backdrop. FAST's miss is the first Q1 data point from the IOWN portfolio and may preview cautious guidance from other industrial-adjacent names in the coming weeks. The broader Q1 earnings cycle begins in earnest today.

S&P 500 (SPY)	**$686.10 · ↑0.98% · Intraday H $686.30**
BRENT CRUDE	**~$98 Tue AM · ↓1% · Reversing Mon's 7% blockade spike**
UVXY	**↓5.61% · Vol compressing despite blockade**
MARCH PPI TODAY	**Est 1.2% MoM · 4.6% YoY · 8:30 AM ET**
NFIB OPTIMISM	**95.8 vs 98.6 est · Miss · 3-pt decline**
FEAR & GREED	**21 · Improving from conflict lows**

The market has spent forty-five days learning to price asymmetric outcomes. Monday's rally through the first resistance band despite an active naval blockade reflects the same dynamic: positioning was underweight risk, and even a partial release of geopolitical premium produces outsized upside. The test now is whether Carson's major resistance at $691.90-$693.20 releases another tranche of supply or absorbs the bid. Think Like an Owner.

SECTION 02

Geopolitics

THE BLOCKADE IS ACTIVE — BUT THE DIPLOMATIC TRACK HAS NOT CLOSED

The US Navy blockade of Iranian ports commenced Monday at 10 AM ET and remains in force. CENTCOM confirmed the operation targets only vessels originating from or destined for Iranian ports; transit through the Strait for non-Iranian commerce is unimpeded. Iran denounced the action as piracy and staged protests in Tehran, while the UK's refusal to participate and China's call for restraint have left the US operation largely unilateral among Western powers. However, reports cited by Al Jazeera indicate that Trump stated Tehran wants a deal, and Pakistan has offered to host a second round of talks in Islamabad. The market interpretation: the blockade is a pressure tactic within an ongoing negotiation, not a permanent rupture. If that reading holds, the current two-week ceasefire window (announced April 8) could be extended via fresh negotiations before the underlying hostilities resume. If it proves incorrect, the blockade evolves into a sustained military operation with open-ended supply chain consequences.

OIL RETREATS ON NEGOTIATION SIGNALS — BRENT GIVES BACK THE BLOCKADE PREMIUM

Brent crude fell approximately 1% to $98 in early Tuesday trading, with WTI down to $96.57. The reversal unwinds a portion of Monday's 7% blockade-driven surge and reflects market repricing around the renewed negotiation reports. Analysts cited by CNBC note that the blockade's practical impact may be limited given that Hormuz transit had already been substantially disrupted since Iran's selective-access regime was imposed in March; the blockade formalizes the disruption rather than materially extending it. For the IOWN energy sleeve, this reprices the war-premium trade: CVX (+1.71% Monday), VLO (+1.36%), and OKE (–1.02%) are transitioning from a war-premium-expansion trade to a structural-disruption-persistence trade. The thesis remains intact given that Hormuz reopening to pre-war levels would still require extensive reconstruction and verification.

BLOCKADE STATUS	**Active since Mon 10 AM ET · Non-Iranian transit unimpeded**
NEGOTIATION REPORTS	**Trump: Tehran wants deal · Pakistan offers 2nd round**
ALLIED POSITION	**UK not participating · China urges restraint**
OIL REVERSAL	**Brent ↓1% to ~$98 · WTI ~$96.57**
CEASEFIRE WINDOW	**Two-week framework from April 8 · Could be extended**

SECTION 03

On Our Radar

1. March PPI at 8:30 AM ET is today's primary data release. Headline PPI is projected at +1.2% MoM and +4.6% YoY, accelerating from +0.7% and +3.4% respectively. Core PPI is expected at +0.6% MoM and +4.2% YoY. Upstream pricing pressure has been building for three months, with ISM Manufacturing Prices at 78.3 in March and energy inputs elevated throughout Q1. An in-line or hotter print reinforces the zero-cut Fed posture for 2026 and pressures rate-sensitive holdings (NEE –1.89% Monday, BKH –2.21%, EIX –4.40%). A soft print would suggest the energy pass-through is contained to headline. Research Reveals Opportunities.

2. Q1 bank earnings accelerate today with JPM, Wells Fargo, Citigroup, and BlackRock. Consensus estimates: JPM $5.41, WFC $1.58, Citi $2.63, BLK $12.26. Zacks projects Citigroup EPS growth of 34% and Wells Fargo at 24% year-over-year, both benefiting from favorable prior-year comparisons. Goldman Sachs reported Monday. JNJ also reports today; ABT (IOWN) reports Thursday, April 16, with pre-announced Q1 guidance of $1.12-$1.18 per share, bracketing the $1.15 analyst consensus, and FY guidance set at $5.55-$5.80 versus $5.67 consensus. The ABT print later this week matters for diagnostic sector read-through to DGX. **The physical world matters.**

3. Three Fed speakers are on the calendar this afternoon. Goolsbee speaks at 4:15 PM ET, Barr at 4:45 PM ET, and Collins at 5:00 PM ET. Markets will parse commentary for any shift in the zero-cut baseline given the stagflation signal from the CPI/PPI combination. Warsh's Fed Chair confirmation hearing remains delayed pending paperwork per prior reports. The current framework prices the Fed on indefinite hold through at least mid-year. Rate-sensitive holdings face structural headwinds in this environment even as the ceasefire reduces near-term energy risk. Simplicity Over Complexity.

4. The two-week ceasefire window and the blockade are on parallel clocks. The April 8 ceasefire framework expires around April 22 absent extension. The blockade has no stated end date and will remain in effect until Iran opens the Strait to all traffic—a demand Tehran has consistently rejected. If negotiations produce a framework extension, oil retraces further and the equity rally extends. If the window closes without progress, the energy and defense sleeves reassert. The portfolio is positioned through both outcomes. Avoid Erosion.

5. Carson's major resistance at SPY $691.90-$693.20 is the focal point for technical positioning. Carson expects a meaningful concentration of sell-side order flow in this zone. A breakout through the upper bound opens the path toward all-time highs on his framework; failure to clear it sets up a potential rotation back toward the intermediate band and, over a longer horizon, the $645.80 support. Today's PPI and bank earnings will be the fundamental catalysts testing this technical level. **Think Like an Owner.**

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